We did rediscover our intensity against the United Arab Emirates in Wellington, and I managed to score 99 not out in our total of 341 for six in 50 overs, before we bowled them out for 195. Two of the UAE batsman, Saqlain Haider and Amjad Javed, suffered the indignity of being dismissed by a part-time dibbly-dobbly bowler of medium pace, who finished with figures of two for 15 from three overs. His name was De Villiers.

Five weeks after the first game, the tournament finally reached the last eight stage and, after finishing second in Group B behind India, we prepared to play a quarterfinal against Sri Lanka in Sydney.

None of us needed reminding of the bleak reality that, in all the history of World Cup cricket, no South African team had ever won a knockout match, not one. It was a wretched record and, when the squad gathered at 6 pm on the eve of what would be a huge match, I tried to find the right words:

I want to read part of this letter I have received from John Smit [captain of the Springbok team that won the Rugby World Cup in 2007]. There's one piece that stands out for me. 'You chaps have created something special over the last few seasons and, for me, that is the difference between my three World Cups. The one we brought home was the one where our team had the strongest family bond. For me, in life, family is a massive deal and being a father made me truly understand the meaning of being in a team: being responsible for one another, supporting each other, defending each other blindly and having a deep-rooted desire for each of your family members.'

I think that's exactly what it's about.

There are a few things I want to say.

First, it won't be easy. It's never going to be easy, boys, especially in the quarterfinal of the World Cup. I know we're going